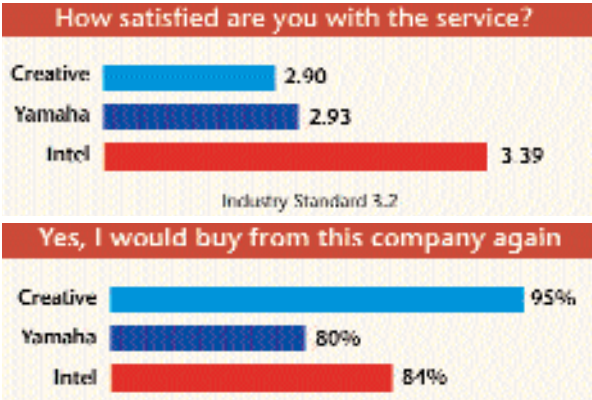




drivers are a frigging joke”; led some people to declare rather unflattering things about Creative’s offerings. One Dinesh Goyal, a businessman is especially vitriolic, “I feel like a fool having spent so much money for a piece of s***!” Meanwhile, a reader in Chennai, Prakash

Dugar, a chartered accountant, wonders if he will ever get support for Creative’s products in his state. While Yamaha comes across as a more stable solution (keeping in mind its share of votes), it too faces driver problems, especially under newer operating systems: “performance is satisfactory, but the Web site does not have drivers for all products under Windows XP,” complains Abhishek Malhotra, from New Delhi.

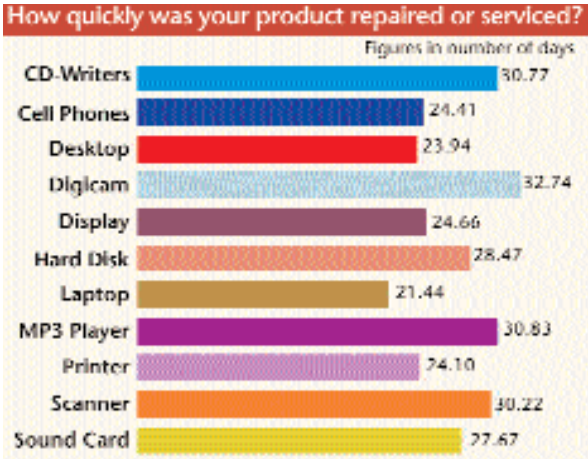
MOST RELIABLE SOUND CARD: Creative RUNNER-UP: Yamaha
MOST RELIABLE SERVICE: Intel RUNNER-UP Yamaha

Final Thoughts

The survey threw up some interesting numbers. Take desktop computers: the segment charted a Reliability Index of 3.63, the lowest across all categories, as opposed to the industry standard of 4.50. It repeated the offence under the Service Index as well, which transforms this product category into the most-troublesome device in the industry. This is quite a disappointing showing, considering that a PC is the primary means of work, communication and is an industry driver. Little wonder that corporations spend more on servicing and maintenance of their systems than on procurement of the same. Initiatives such as the grid-enabled Autonomic Computing—wherein the mantra of self-healing, self-aware, self-protecting, self-configuring and self-optimising computers is repeatedly chanted with the hope of attaining computing nirvana—promise hope but only time will tell if they will deliver.

Another point to note is that products which did not score well on the Reliability

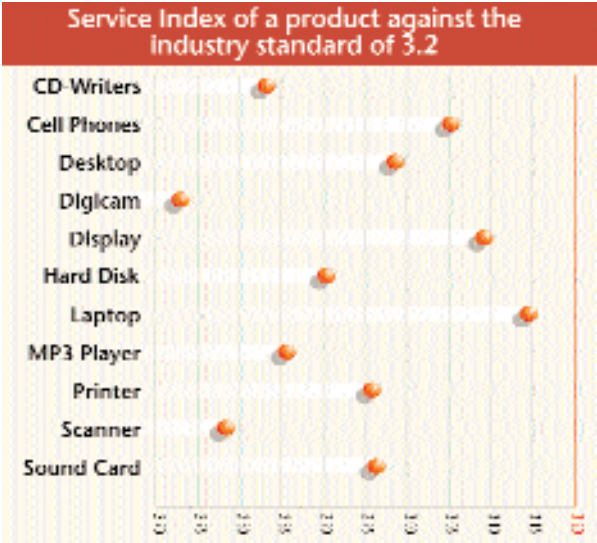
and Service Index had very positive perceptions in the minds of consumers. This dichotomy between fact and perception can be traced to the strength of the particular brand. Sony, for example, seems to be especially blessed in this regard. With comments such as “The name says it all,” Sony is sitting pretty in the mind-space of consumers. For digital cameras, 98 per cent of respondents claimed that they would buy a Sony again, note however that in that category, Nikon did the best in both the Reliability and the Service Index (87 per cent of the 169 respondents would buy a Nikon again). Is a Nikon owner wondering whether a different company would offer him or her, a better product or a better service? A case of the grass is greener on



the other side or of branding, or both?

Support and service, both technical and personal, are important facets of a purchase. We hope this survey has served its purpose of throwing light on the after-sale corner of technology.

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MOST TROUBLESOME DEVICE : **Desktop computer**
MOST TROUBLE-FREE DEVICE: **Sound Card**

